



**Canadian Mental
Health Association**
Edmonton
Mental health for all

UNDERSTANDING AISH & ADAP

A Guide to Recent Changes

An outline of the changes to Alberta's disability assistance system, including eligibility, benefits, applications, appeals, financial rules, and available support resources.

CMHA Edmonton

Understanding AISH & ADAP July 2026

A Practical Guide to the AISH & ADAP Guidelines 2026

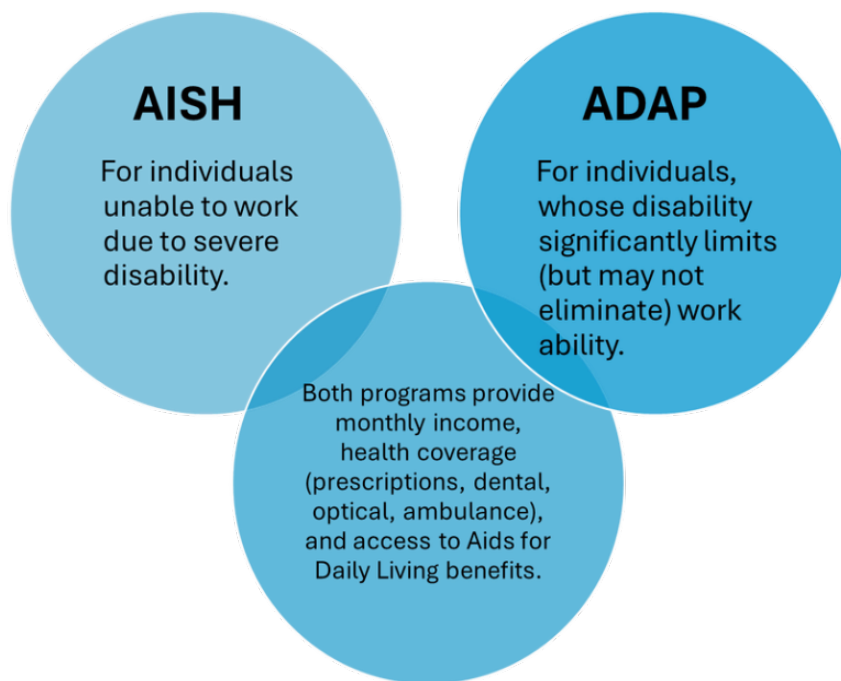
The information contained in this document is based on the most current and up-to-date information available and is subject to change.

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1. What is AISH / ADAP?

- AISH: Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped
- ADAP: Alberta's Disability Income Support Programs
- Until July 1, 2026, AISH was the sole disability income plan in Alberta



2. Understanding the 2026 Transition

As of July 1, 2026, AISH was split into two programs, AISH and ADAP.

- There will be a transition period until December 31, 2027 where individuals transitioned onto ADAP will receive a top-up benefit to match the AISH benefit.
- Individuals who receive AISH should have received letters outlining whether they will remain on AISH or transition to ADAP.
- These letters were sent out and should have been received between mid-May and mid-June 2026.
- Individuals receiving AISH who have been identified as remaining on AISH will not need to do anything.

Individuals who will remain on AISH are:

- Individuals with severe and profound developmental disabilities or, who are deemed eligible as Persons with Developmental Disabilities
- Individuals with palliative or terminal medical conditions
- Individuals living in continual care homes
- Individuals who are 60 years of age or older

Proposed Monthly Benefits

- AISH: \$1,940 / month
- ADAP: \$1,740 / month

Eligibility

- Must be 18 years of age or older, and live in Alberta
- Must be a Canadian citizen or a permanent resident
- Must have less than \$100,000 in non-exempt assets.
- Must have a severe, long-term disability impacting ability to work

What is a severe disability

- *A disability that qualifies for AISH / ADAP must be:*
 - Permanent, or likely to last at least 2 years as stated by a medical professional
 - Confirmed by medical and psychological reports with an official diagnosis from a provider
 - Actively participating in any recommended treatments for their condition
- *AISH may allow for a few hours of work per week as a means to participate in community*
- *Individuals receiving ADAP who have found that their disabilities are getting worse can apply to be moved to AISH benefits.*

3. Application Overview

AISH and ADAP share the same application and process form

- There are two parts to the application form
 - One part needs to be filled out by the individual applying for AISH/ADAP.
 - One part needs to be filled out by a medical provider.

- The Government of Alberta will cover one medical assessment for individuals who were transitioned to ADAP and chose to be assessed later for AISH.
 - Fees for the assessment will be covered once ONLY
 - There is no time limit associated with the assessment
 - The coverage for the assessment will be applied if and when individuals decide to proceed with the assessment

Disability Assistance Application

- All applicants must fill out a **Disability Assistance Application**
- The application covers general information like the following:
 - Financial information
 - Eligibility
 - Citizenship / residency status
- A case worker, social worker, or trusted friend or family member can help to support individuals while they are filling out the form

Disability Assistance Medical Report

- All individuals applying must have a **Disability Assistance Medical Form** filled out by their medical Doctor
- The report collects information on the following:
 - Individual / patient diagnoses
 - Conditions and ability to work
 - Individuals can choose to have the form completed by their primary medical Doctor or by a pre-qualified professional on the AISH / ADAP list of professional care providers



TIP:

- *It's important that the medical form is completed in a manner that accurately reflects an applicant's disabilities.*
 - *Not all medical professionals are familiar with the Disability Assistance Medical Form.*
 - *It is advisable to discuss what needs to be in the report with medical service providers.*
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How to Advocate with your Physician

- It's important to focus on functional limitations, not just diagnoses
- Discuss worst-day functioning and negative capacity (i.e., activities that can't be performed reliably, safely, or repeatedly)
- Be specific about the frequency and severity of difficulties or challenges
 - For individuals who have difficulty walking:
 - Provide specific examples of what is occurring
 - Example: *For four out of five days of the week, I find it difficult to walk because of pain that can't be controlled by pain medication*
 - It is important that the service provider records this information in the information they provide on the medical report.
 - It would be inaccurate for the medical report to reflect that the patient can walk without pain "sometimes"
- Be as realistic as possible about the permanency of an impairment or injury
- Bring a one-page summary about your illness, injury, impairment, or challenges and include diagnoses, medications, hospitalizations, the daily impact your injury, illness, or condition have on you, provide information about your work history and how this has impacted you in the work environment

- Ask clarifying questions to ensure that any limitations are clearly documented
 - *Detailed documentation can prevent months of delay*
 - *Medical reports are often the determining factor in AISH / ADAP applications*
 - *Application approvals depend on*
 - *Functional limitations*
 - *Impact on employment*
 - *Permanency*

4. How will the transition impact current AISH participants

- On July 1, 2026, the majority of existing AISH recipients were transitioned to ADAP, **with some exceptions.**
- *AISH recipients with very severe disabilities will remain on AISH.*
- AISH recipients who are transitioned to ADAP must apply to be transitioned back to AISH.
- *Individuals with less severe disabilities who would like to transition back to AISH must submit a new Disability Medical Report.*

5. Adjudication and Appeal Process

Adjudication Process

When an application is submitted, a disability adjudicator will review the forms. They will determine if an individual is better suited to AISH / ADAP, or if they don't qualify for disability benefits.

Adjudication Appeal

- An adjudicator may determine whether an individual can qualify for a different level of eligibility.
- They may also determine that an individual is ineligible for benefits
- Anyone who has applied has the right to file an appeal if they do not agree with the decision made by their adjudicator.
- Filing an appeal means that an individual did not agree with the decision made by their adjudicator.

➤ **NOTE: This process will change when ADAP is launched.**

Appeal Process Changes

- ***Appealing a decision before July 1, 2026***
 - Submitted appeals go to the citizen's review panel, and independent body, separate from AISH, whose members do not work for the government
 - This ensures that there is no bias in their judgement
 - The panel reviews applications and works to resolve any issues
 - If a disagreement remains unsolved, an appeal hearing is scheduled
 - Individuals can present information on why they believe a decision should be changed at a hearing.
 - The decision made by the panel is final
- ***Appealing a decision after July 1, 2026***
 - If an individual disagrees with the decision about their eligibility income assistance application, they can appeal the decision.
 - The new medical review panel is a part of AISH / ADAP.
 - The new medical review panel will not allow submissions of new information or for direct communication with the applicant via hearings.
 - Having all medical information updated before appealing is important as panel decisions will be made exclusively on existing reports.
- ***ADAP eligibility decisions***
 - Can be appealed through the ADAP Medical Appeal Panel or the Citizen's Appeal Panel depending on the type of decision that's been made about an individual's eligibility
 - The fillable PDF **Notice of Appeal** form may not open properly on some mobile devices and web browsers and need downloaded to open in Adobe Acrobat.
 - Decisions by a disability assistance adjudicator not to refer someone to the AISH Medical Review Panel for an eligibility determination may be appealed to the ADAP Medical Appeal Panel.
 - An individual may appeal a disability assistance adjudicator's decision that they are not eligible for ADAP.



Appeal Tip

- There are two additional steps individuals can take if they disagree with the appeal decision for specific reasons.

- 1. If an individual believes that the appeal process was unfair or biased, they can file a complaint with the Alberta Ombudsman's office. The Ombudsman can investigate the fairness of the adjudication process, but they cannot overturn the decision. They may formally recommend that the matter be reheard by a different panel.*
- 2. If an individual believes that the appeal process was not only unethical but also unlawful, beyond its legal authority, or unreasonable, they can apply for a judicial review in the Court of King's Bench.*

- Like a complaint made to the Alberta Ombudsman's office, a judicial review examines the fairness of the process rather than the merits of the decision that's been made and cannot directly substitute a new decision. The court may order a new hearing before a panel consisting of different decision-makers, while the Ombudsman may only recommend that the matter be reheard.

6. Benefits and Proposed Changes effective July 1, 2026

AISH / ADAP consist of two main benefits

- A monthly income benefit to assist people with their living expenses
- An extensive combination of health benefits
- The monthly income benefit increases each year to keep up with inflation
- *The chart below covers the proposed changes and numbers that are accurate as of 2026.*

Monthly Income Benefits

- AISH will maintain its current benefit rate
- Under the new ADAP program, monthly benefits will be reduced by \$200
- A transition period from July 1, 2026, to December 31, 2027, will apply to individuals transitioning to ADAP
- Individuals transitioning to ADAP will temporarily receive the full \$1,940, until December 31, 2027, to allow time to transition back to AISH, if appropriate
- *Individuals who apply for and are approved for ADAP benefits after July 1, 2026, will start at the rate of \$1,740 per month*

Personal Health Benefits

- AISH / ADAP cover a wide variety of personal health costs, such as prescription medication, dental, optical, and ambulances.
- Earning enough income to reduce the monthly benefit does not impact personal health benefits.
- *Individuals will continue to receive health benefits after earnings rise above eligibility thresholds.*



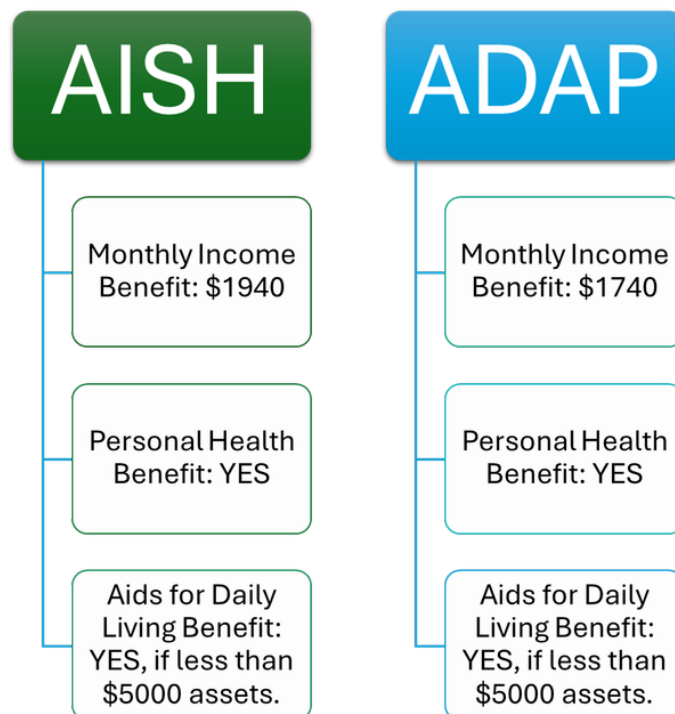
Medication TIPS

- *If a medication has a brand name and a generic option, AISH / ADAP will cover the cost of the generic medication*
 - *Individuals have the option to access brand name prescriptions if they pay the remaining balance*
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Child Benefit Rates

- Individuals with dependents can expect the updated rates in their monthly benefits.
- **Recalibrated child benefit rates for individuals on AISH or ADAP**
 - \$300 for the first child
 - \$117 for the second
 - \$88 for the third
 - \$59 for the fourth
 - \$30 for each additional child.

7. Benefit Breakdown



8. Assets

Assets are property or resources owned by individuals applying for AISH / ADAP, and depending on the type of asset, it may be:

- Fully exempt
- Partially exempt
- Non-exempt for eligibility purposes.
- To remain eligible for disability support, the total value of non-exempt assets must not exceed \$100,000.

Exempt assets

Most exempt assets include items that are essential for everyday living.

- These typically include: an individual's primary home; clothing and reasonable household furnishings; one vehicle (with a second permitted if it has been specially modified to accommodate a disability); and assets such as a Registered Disability Savings Plan (RDSP) or a trust.

Partially exempt or non-exempt assets

The following assets count toward the asset limit:

- Recreational properties or second homes; recreational vehicles such as ATVs or boats; and most financial holdings outside an RDSP or trust, including cash, chequing and savings accounts, Registered Retirement Savings Plans (RRSPs), Tax-Free Savings Account (TFSA), and inherited funds.

Exemption Window

If an individual receives a significant amount of non-exempt funds, such as an inheritance or proceeds from the sale of a vehicle or property, they have 365 days (one year) to transfer those funds into an exempt asset before they are counted toward the asset limit.

9. Exemptions

Legacy AISH Exemption Rate

For employment income, the first \$1,072 is fully exempt, the next portion (up to \$2,009) is 50% exempt, and any income above \$2,009 reduces benefits dollar-for-dollar.

Current Exemption Rates as of July 1, 2026

- The following is a chart of proposed exemptions provided by the Government of Alberta. Amounts that are not finalized.

PROPOSED AISH AND ADAP TREATMENT OF INCOME

Income Type	AISH	ADAP
Employment and self-employment income	Client: Partially exempt. First \$350/month fully exempt, remaining amounts deducted at 100%.	Client (single, no dependents): Partially exempt. First \$700/month fully exempt (does not impact financial benefits), remaining amounts gradually deducted at increasing levels. Will be gradually deducted starting with less than a cent per dollar and increasing significantly as approaching \$45,000 employment income per year. Albertans on ADAP will be able to earn up to \$45,240 annually in employment income while continuing to receive financial benefits.
	Spouse /Cohabiting Partner: Partially exempt. First \$1,500/month fully exempt, remaining amounts gradually deducted at increasing levels until full	Client (with dependents): Partially exempt. First \$1,100/month fully exempt. Spouse/Cohabiting Partner: Partially exempt. First \$1500/month fully exempt.
Passive business income (e.g. interest, trust, and rental income)	Client (single, no dependents): Partially exempt. First \$300/month fully exempt, remaining amounts deducted at 75%	
Pension income (e.g. CPP, OAS, GIS, EI, WCB)	Client (single parent) and couples: Partially exempt. First \$600/month fully exempt, remaining amounts deducted at 75%	
	Client: non-exempt (deducted at 100%) Spouse /Cohabiting Partner: Partially exempt. First \$1,200/month of spousal pension income will be fully exempt, and 25% of the remaining amount will also be exempt.	

10. Canada Disability Tax Credit and Canada Disability Benefit

What is the Canada Disability Tax Credit (CDTC)?	What does it do?	Why does it matter?	How to Apply
A federal tax credit for people living with disabilities.	Reduces income tax owed and may result in a refund.	If approved, individuals may qualify for the Canada Disability Benefit.	1).CRA Online Account 2).By phone 3).In person at a Service Canada location.

Canada Disability Benefit (CDB)

The CDB is a federal income benefit for people with disabilities across Canada.

- **Amount**

- Maximum of \$204.20 per month as of 2026
- \$2,450.40 per year
- Adjusted annually for inflation

Income rules

- CDB has its own income exemption thresholds.
- The thresholds are different from AISH/ADAP.

11. Important for Individuals Receiving AISH / ADAP in Alberta

- To remain eligible for AISH / ADAP, individuals must apply for all other available disability income programs, including the CDB (Canada Disability Benefit).
- In Alberta, benefits are currently reduced by one dollar for every dollar received.
- If you receive \$204.20 from the CDB, your AISH / ADAP benefit will be reduced by \$204.20 per month.
- This means that the CDB does not currently increase total monthly income for AISH / ADAP recipients in Alberta.
- ADAP recipients may be refused benefits if they refuse reasonable employment or employment supports, if they neglect to participate in employment initiatives and programs, or if they reduce their work hours or employment income.
- ADAP structures will include benefits for training fees, tools, work-related goods and services, and employability supports.
- Partner exemptions will cover 100% of the first \$1,200 of income and 25% of any additional income from the following sources only: the Canada Disability Benefit, CPP, Employment Insurance, Workers' Compensation, and pension income.

12.ADAP Employment Supports

What employment supports are available for ADAP clients?

Employment services for ADAP clients will include career planning, assistive technology and supported job placements, as well as resources to help employers break down accessibility barriers in their workplace. All ADAP clients are referred to the Prime Contractors. In Edmonton and Calgary, the Prime Contractors coordinate the full pathway, including assessments, coordinating to other supports beyond employment, and connecting clients to an employment services provider. In smaller urban and rural areas, the Prime Contractors connect clients directly to an employment service provider, who delivers comprehensive services and coordinates access locally.

All ADAP clients will undergo an assessment to see how their disability impacts employment readiness and what supports they need. They will then make a personalized employment action plan with their provider. Employment services will coordinate supports beyond employment to address barriers such as transportation, health and disability-related needs, enabling clients to participate consistently and make sustained progress.

Connections to employment services providers based on a client's personalized plan, may include:

- digital services
- in-person support at employment centers
- simulated worksites
- career planning
- assistive technology
- education supports
- resume assistance
- interview preparation
- short-term training
- supported job placements

ADAP clients will have access to digital, and in-person supports. ADAP clients will receive 12 months of on-going support, post employment services, to ensure support in a job, or continue to support to get a job. If an ADAP client is unable to find a job after receiving employment supports, they will continue to receive their financial and health benefits. If their medical condition progresses to the point that they are unable to work, they can apply for the AISH program.

How are Alberta employers being engaged to ensure there are jobs available for ADAP clients?

The ministry is strengthening engagement and support to employers to hire and sustain a diverse workforce, including for job seekers and employees with disabilities.

This includes:

- job design
- recruitment services, including candidate screening, onboarding and retention support
- labour market information sharing
- information referrals and resources
- employment promotion services

What if an ADAP client is unable to find a job?

If an ADAP client is unable to find a job after receiving employment services, they will continue to receive financial and health benefits. ADAP clients can apply for an AISH assessment if their medical condition or ability to work changes.

13. Connecting to Services & Supports

2-1-1:

- You can reach 2-1-1 by dialing 2-1-1, by text, and online.
- For information on how to reach 2-1-1 see the web site
 - <https://ab.211.ca/>

9-8-8: Suicide Crisis Helpline (24/7)

- Are you thinking about suicide, or worried about someone else?
- Call or text 9-8-8 for free, confidential support 24/7.
- 9-8-8 is a safe space to talk

The Edmonton Distress Line

- Those in crisis can get connected through the CMHA-ER Distress Line
 - 780-482-HELP (4357)

Drop-in Single Session Counselling

- Drop-in, no cost, single-session counselling for individuals, couples, and families
- Flexible days and times
- Counselling is available via phone, or online
- To book a phone or online counselling session:
 - <https://tfc.clinicmaster.com/clinic-selection>
- By phone: 780.423.2831
- For locations in Edmonton: <https://www.dropinyeg.ca/locations/>

AISH & ADAP Online Benefit Estimator Tool

- Provides an estimate based on household members and structure and employment income earned by individuals and their partners, or spouses (if applicable)
- <https://www.alberta.ca/aish-and-adap-benefit-estimator>

ADAP Official Welcome Package

- [Welcome to ADAP - Brochure](#)